India'.[2] But that was not all. At the foot of Peacock Hill was a huge mound entirely made up of what appeared to be petrified ash. Similar mounds had earlier been spotted in the Bellary area and at half a dozen other sites on the Deccan. Since they appeared to have a glassy surface and gave out a hollow sound when struck they were assumed to be volcanic. However, as reported by Thomas Newbold, a young officer in the Madras Infantry with an unusually enquiring mind, the local view was that these mounds were organic, being 'the burnt bones of enormous giants or *Rakshas* [demons] of old, immolated during the demi-fabulous periods of the *Mahabharata*. All were agreed as to their great antiquity.'[3]

Back in the 1840s Newbold had examined one of these mysterious mounds and compared the contents with ashes found in Hindu funeral pyres. Newbold had concluded that the mounds were entirely composed of bones burned in 'continuous and long continued fires', the result of mass cremations of either cattle, 'the remains of great sacrificial holocausts performed by the *Rishis* [Hindu sages] of old', or humans, the outcomes of 'the bloody struggles that took place between the early Brahminical settlers in Southern India and the savage aboriginals, handed down in the records of the former as *Rakshasas*, giants and demons'.

Foote took a more scientific approach and his researches showed that the great mounds were the outcome of repeated firings of huge piles of cow-dung, produced by generations of cattle-herding pastoralists during the Neolithic period and after. He speculated that these great pyres must have played an important part in the religious rituals of these cattle-herding peoples.

Foote's theories were subsequently proved correct by the field-work begun by Raymond Allchin and others in the 1960s.[4] Their excavations revealed post-holes for tethered cattle as well as earthworks in the form of great corrals in